8-WEEK PLAN

Bodyweight

8 weeks, no gym.

Days 4 a week **Session** 45 min **Equipment** Pull-up bar, two sturdy chairs
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What this is

This is a four-day upper/lower split that runs on a pull-up bar, two chairs and a floor. I built it for the weeks when there is no gym: travel, a home setup, a maintenance block between harder programs. Two upper days, one biased to pushing and one to pulling, and two lower days, so each muscle gets two hard exposures a week with rest between them. What makes bodyweight work is leverage. Without plates, you change the resistance by changing your position: hands up on a chair makes a push-up easier, feet up on a chair makes it harder, one arm makes it hardest. Every movement here sits on a ladder of those positions. The eight weeks teach you to find your rung on each ladder, hold it until it is yours, and climb. Week 8 re-tests week 1 so you leave with a number, not a feeling.

Who it's for

- You have no gym access, or lose it often enough that a gym plan keeps breaking.
- You travel for work and need something that runs from a hotel room or a park.
- You train at home with almost nothing.
- You are between harder blocks and want to hold what you built.

Who it's not for

- You want maximal lower-body size or absolute strength. Legs grow best under heavy external load, and a pistol squat is a skill, not a squat rack. This plan keeps your legs strong. It is not the fastest road to big ones.

Equipment: a pull-up bar (doorway or park), two sturdy chairs, and one elevated surface (a step, a bench, a table). Optional: a resistance band, a backpack you can load with books or water bottles, rings or a suspension trainer. No pull-up bar at all is covered in the pull session.

Before you start

Five rules. They are the plan.

1. **The plan is decided before the week starts.** You do not choose the session on the day. You open the log, read what is written, and do it.
2. **Weekly averages, never single weigh-ins.** Your weight swings two to five pounds a day from water and food. One number is noise. Weigh daily if you like, but the only number you act on is the seven-day average.
3. **A missed day is data, not failure.** It tells you what in the plan does not fit your life yet. Write it down and move on.
4. **Log every session.** The plan works off the record. Here that means the rung, the reps per set, and the tempo used. "Push-up, rung 3, 11, 10, 9, 8, 3-0-1-0" is a log entry. "Did push-ups" is not.
5. **Progress is checked against the record, not against how you feel.** Feeling strong is not a rung. Twelve clean reps is a rung.

Finding your starting rung

There are no weights in this plan, so there are no starting loads. There are starting rungs. Week 1, session 1 of each day type is a rung-finding session. For each movement, start at the lowest rung on its ladder and do a set of 12 at the tempo in the table. If 12 was easy, rest two minutes and try the next rung up. Stop at the rung where 12 clean reps is hard but possible. Clean means full range, the tempo held on every rep, no kipping, no sagging

hips, no hand helping where the rung says free. That is your week-1 rung. Write it down for every movement. It is what you re-test against in week 8.

If you cannot do 12 clean reps on the lowest rung of a ladder, that rung is still your rung. Build reps there. The pull-up ladder starts at an inverted row for this reason.

The warm-up

Five to ten minutes, the same every session. Two minutes of easy movement: a brisk walk, jogging in place, or jumping jacks. Then, in order: ten arm circles each direction, ten shoulder dislocates with a towel or band, ten cat-cow, ten bodyweight squats, ten hip hinges, ten scapular pull-ups or scapular push-ups depending on the day. Then one easy set of the first movement one rung below your working rung. Then begin.

If something hurts in a way that isn't muscle fatigue, stop and see a professional. This plan is not medical advice.

The eight weeks

This plan does not progress by adding plates. It progresses by leverage, then tempo, then load. The table is a map of when you pull each lever.

WEEK	WHAT CHANGES	RUNG RULE	NOTES
1	Rung-finding on every ladder	Find the rung where 12 clean reps is hard but possible	Log the rung and the reps for every movement. This is your baseline.
2	Same rungs, build reps	Hold the rung. Work every set toward 12 clean reps	Stop every set at two reps in reserve except the last set of each movement, which goes to one.
3	Same rungs, add tempo	Hold the rung. Eccentric goes from 3 seconds to 5	Reps will drop. That is the point. Rebuild them at the slower tempo.
4	Same rungs, add pauses	Hold the rung. 5-second eccentric plus a 2-second pause in the hardest position	The last set of every movement finishes with a 10 to 20 second isometric hold.
5	Step up a rung	Any ladder where you hit 12 clean reps at the week-4 tempo moves up one rung. Tempo returns to the table	Rebuild from 6 to 8 reps on the new rung. Ladders that did not hit 12 stay put and keep the slow tempo.
6	Hold the new rung, build reps	Same rungs as week 5. Work every set toward 12	Nothing moves up in week 6. Rep building only.
7	Hold the rung, add load	Same rungs. Add a loaded backpack or a band where the Ladders table marks a loaded rung. Where it does not, add one rest-pause on the final set	Loaded means a backpack with 5 to 10 lb of books or bottles. Start light. The tempo does not change.
8	Re-test	First three sessions: same as week 7. Last session of each day type: drop back to your week-1 rung and do max clean reps at 3-0-1-0	Log the week-8 number next to the week-1 number. That is what you walk away with.

The progression rule in prose

Leverage is your load. The rule is simple. If you can do 12 clean reps at a rung, that rung is no longer hard enough, and you move up. If you cannot do 6 clean reps at the next rung, you are not ready for it, and you make the current rung harder another way. The other ways are tempo and load.

Tempo comes first because it costs nothing. A 3-second lowering is the standard, 5 seconds is harder, 10 seconds is much harder. Weeks 3 and 4 use tempo to make your week-1 rung heavy again without moving you off it. If in week 5 you can do 12 at the slow tempo, the next rung is within reach.

Load comes last because it needs a backpack or a band, and only makes sense once the movement is clean. Week 7 adds it on the ladders that have a loaded rung. On the ladders that do not, the week-7 lever is rest-pause: go to one rep in reserve, rest 10 to 15 seconds, go again to one rep in reserve, and count the whole thing as one set.

Ladders move at different speeds. Your push-up might climb in week 5 while your pull-up stays where it started for all eight weeks. That is normal. Assisted pull-up to full pull-up can take months. Log each ladder separately

and judge it separately.

The week-8 re-test uses week-1 rungs at the standard tempo so the comparison is honest. Twelve reps at rung 2 in week 1 and twenty at rung 2 in week 8 is the number.

Deload triggers

Any one of these fires a deload, the same week, then you resume where you were:

- Reps on a key movement (push-up, single-leg squat, pull-up or row) drop two sessions in a row at the same rung and tempo.
- Five days of feeling flat and heavy.
- A week of bad sleep.

A deload week is half the sets, one rung down on every ladder, standard tempo, three to four reps in reserve, no holds, no rest-pause. Then pick the plan up at the week you left.

The sessions

The ladders

Every movement in the sessions sits on one of these twelve ladders. Rung 1 is easiest. Rungs marked with a tempo or a load are the same position made harder by a different lever. Log the rung number next to each movement.

MOVEMENT FAMILY	RUNG 1	RUNG 2	RUNG 3	RUNG 4	RUNG 5
Push-up	Incline, hands on a chair or table	Flat, hands on the floor	Decline, feet on a chair	Archer, one arm straight out to the side, assisting	One-arm
Pike push-up	Pike, feet on the floor, hips high	Pike, feet on a chair	Wall handstand push-up	Wall handstand push-up, 5-second eccentric	Freestanding handstand push-up
Dip	Assisted, feet on the floor or a band under the knees	Full dip between two chairs	Full dip, 5-second eccentric	Loaded dip, backpack	Ring dip
Triceps extension	Incline, hands on a chair or table	Flat, hands on the floor	Decline, feet on a chair	Decline, 5-second eccentric	One-arm, incline
Single-leg squat	Assisted pistol, holding a doorframe or a band	Rear-foot-elevated split squat, back foot on a chair	Full pistol squat, freestanding	Full pistol, 5-second eccentric	Loaded pistol, backpack
Nordic curl	Assisted, hands take most of the work	Eccentric only, lower slow, push up with hands	Full, light hand assist at the bottom	Full, no hands	Full, no hands, 5-second eccentric
Single-leg Romanian deadlift	Bodyweight, one hand on a wall	Bodyweight, free standing	Bodyweight, 5-second eccentric	Loaded, backpack	Loaded, 5-second eccentric
Single-leg calf raise	Two legs on a step	One leg on a step	One leg with the interset stretch	One leg, loaded backpack	One leg, loaded, with the stretch
Pull-up	Inverted row under a table or low bar, feet on the floor	Inverted row, feet on a chair	Assisted pull-up, band under the feet	Full pull-up	Loaded pull-up, backpack
Inverted row, high elbow	Feet on the floor, body at a steep angle	Feet on the floor, body horizontal	Feet on a chair	Feet on a chair, loaded backpack	One-arm
Plank to down dog	On the knees	Full plank	Feet on a chair	Feet on a chair, 5-second each way	Feet on a chair, 2-second pause at the top

MOVEMENT FAMILY	RUNG 1	RUNG 2	RUNG 3	RUNG 4	RUNG 5
Chin-up	Band curl, or towel isometric against a doorframe	Assisted chin-up, band under the feet	Full chin-up	Full chin-up, 5-second eccentric	Loaded chin-up, backpack

Tempo is four numbers. 3-0-1-0 means three seconds down, no pause at the bottom, one second up, no pause at the top. 3-1-1-0 adds a one-second pause in the stretched position. The way down is where bodyweight training does its work.

Day 1, Upper push

Focus: chest, shoulders and triceps through the push-up, pike and dip ladders. Every set stops at two reps in reserve, the last set of each movement at one.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Push-up (ladder rung)	4	8-12	3-0-1-0	2-3 min	Hands a little wider than the shoulders, elbows at 45 degrees, chest to the floor, full lockout. Rung from the Ladders table. Weeks 3-4 tempo lever: 5-0-1-0, then 5-2-1-0. Week 7 lever: rest-pause on the last set.
Pike push-up (ladder rung)	3	8-12	3-0-1-0	2 min	Hips high, head travels toward the floor between the hands, press back. Core tight, no sag. Rung from the Ladders table. Weeks 3-4: tempo lever. Week 7: rest-pause on the last set. Handstand rungs stay on the wall.
Dip between chairs (ladder rung)	3	8-12	3-0-1-0	2 min	Two chairs facing each other, hands on the seats. Lean forward for chest, upright for triceps. Shoulders below the elbows at the bottom, or as deep as your shoulders allow. No shrug at the top. Weeks 3-4: tempo lever. Week 7: loaded rung with a backpack.
Triceps extension, bodyweight (ladder rung)	3	8-12	3-0-1-0	90 sec	Hands on the chair or floor, feet walked back so the body is a straight line at an angle. Bend only at the elbows, head toward the hands, elbows tucked. Weeks 3-4: tempo lever. Week 7: rest-pause on the last set. Last set every week ends with an isometric hold, 10 to 20 seconds at the bottom.

An isometric hold means staying in the hardest position of the movement after the last rep, for 10 to 30 seconds. On the push-up that is chest an inch off the floor. It extends time under tension when you have no plates to add. Final set only.

Substitutions. No chairs for dips: bench dips with hands on one chair and feet on the floor, or a slow decline push-up. Rings or a suspension trainer: ring push-up, ring dip. Parallettes or push-up bars: deeper range on push-ups. Pseudo planche push-ups (hands turned out, set by the hips) replace the archer rung if the archer bothers your wrists. The standard order, machine then dumbbell then cable then bodyweight, ends where this plan starts.

Day 2, Lower A

Focus: quads through the single-leg squat ladder, hamstrings through the Nordic ladder, calves with the interset stretch. All single-leg work is done for the stated reps on each leg, weaker leg first.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Single-leg squat (ladder rung)	4	8-12 each leg	3-1-1-0	3 min	Knee tracks over the toes, no caving. The free leg does not help. Three seconds down, one-second pause, drive up. Rung from the Ladders table. Weeks 3-4: 5-2-1-0. Week 7: loaded rung with a backpack. On a pistol rung, a hand on the doorframe for the last rep is fine, log it as assisted.
Nordic curl (ladder rung)	4	8-12	3-1-1-0	2-3 min	Ankles anchored under a couch or held by a band. Lower the torso forward as slowly as you can, catch with the hands, push back up with the hands if your rung allows. Rung from the Ladders table. Weeks 3-4: 5-second lowering. Week 7: rest-pause on the last set. Soft surface under the knees.
Single-leg calf raise with interset stretch	3-4	15 each leg	3-0-1-30	2 min	Edge of a step, one foot. Fifteen reps to one rep in reserve, then on the last rep drop into the deep stretch at the bottom and hold 20 to 30 seconds. That hold is the interset stretch, the fourth tempo number. Rest, then the other leg. Week 7: loaded rung.

Interset stretching means holding the fully stretched position for 20 to 30 seconds straight after the final rep of a set. It is uncomfortable. It is the main growth lever for calves in a plan with no machine. From here it is just "the stretch".

Substitutions. Single-leg squat: rear-foot-elevated split squat, shrimp squat, or jump squat. Nordic curl: single-leg Romanian deadlift at its matching rung, or sliding leg curl (heels on a towel on a smooth floor, hips up, drag the heels in). Calf raise: skipping rope or box jumps if there is no step.

Day 3, Upper pull

Focus: back width through the pull-up ladder, back thickness through the high-elbow row, then shoulders, rear delts and biceps. The longest session. Short on time, drop the plank to down dog, never the rows.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Pull-up (ladder rung)	4	8-12	3-1-1-0	2-3 min	Overhand grip, hands a little wider than the shoulders. Elbows down and back, chest to the bar, three seconds down, one-second pause in the hang. No kipping. Rung from the Ladders table. The bottom two rungs are rows and need no bar. Weeks 3-4: tempo lever. Week 7: loaded rung, or rest-pause if still on a row rung.
Inverted row, high elbow (ladder rung)	4	8-12	3-1-1-0	2 min	Under a table, a low bar, or rings. Elbows at or above shoulder height, pull to the chest, one-second squeeze. Stop when the upper back stops contracting, before the traps take over. Weeks 3-4: tempo lever. Week 7: loaded rung.
Pike push-up (ladder rung)	3	8-12	3-0-1-0	2 min	Same rung and cues as Day 1. Weeks 3-4: tempo lever. Week 7: rest-pause on the last set.
Plank to down dog (ladder rung)	3	8-12	3-0-1-0	90 sec	From a plank, push the hips up and back into a pike, three seconds each way, return. The shoulder extension does the job of a rear delt fly. Rung from the Ladders table. Weeks 3-4: tempo lever. Week 7: 2-second pause at the top.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Chin-up (ladder rung)	4	8-12	3-0-1-0	90 sec	Underhand grip, chest to the bar, three seconds down. Rung from the Ladders table. Rung 1 needs no bar: band curls, or a towel pulled against a doorframe for a 20 to 30 second isometric, counted as one set. Weeks 3-4: tempo lever. Week 7: loaded rung. Last set every week ends with an isometric hold, chin over the bar, 10 to 20 seconds.

No pull-up bar at all. Doorway rows: loop a towel over the top of a closed door, grip both ends, lean back and row. Table rows: slide under a sturdy table, grip the edge, pull the chest to the underside. Band pull-downs: anchor a band overhead, pull to the chest. Outdoors: playground bars, or a tree branch tested with your full weight first. Run the pull-up and chin-up rows on those, logged as rung 1 or 2.

Substitutions. Pull-up: chin-up, commando pull-up (hands in line, alternate sides), or a muscle-up if you are far up the ladder. Inverted row: suspension trainer row, towel row. Plank to down dog: band pull-apart. Chin-up: band curl, towel isometric.

Day 4, Lower B

Focus: the same patterns as Lower A with the hinge done as a single-leg Romanian deadlift instead of a Nordic. Weaker leg first, every movement.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Single-leg squat (ladder rung)	4	8-12 each leg	3-1-1-0	3 min	Same rung as Lower A. The rung moves on both days or neither. Weeks 3-4: 5-2-1-0. Week 7: loaded rung with a backpack. If reps fall below 6 from Lower A soreness, hold the rung and log the drop.
Single-leg Romanian deadlift (ladder rung)	4	8-12 each leg	3-1-1-0	2-3 min	Hinge at the hips, free leg straight back for balance, lower until the hamstring stretch stops you. Three seconds down, one-second pause at the stretch, return. Rung from the Ladders table. Weeks 3-4: tempo lever. Week 7: loaded rung. Last set ends with a 20-second hold at the stretch.
Single-leg calf raise with the stretch	3-4	15 each leg	3-0-1-30	2 min	Same as Lower A. Fifteen reps, then the stretch for 20 to 30 seconds. Week 7: loaded rung.

Substitutions. Single-leg squat: as Lower A. Single-leg Romanian deadlift: Nordic curl at its matching rung, or sliding leg curl. Calf raise: as Lower A.

The week

DAY	SESSION
Monday	Day 1, Upper push
Tuesday	Day 2, Lower A
Wednesday	Rest, walk
Thursday	Day 3, Upper pull

DAY	SESSION
Friday	Day 4, Lower B
Saturday	Rest, walk
Sunday	Rest, walk

The rolling alternative, for travel weeks and shift work: Upper push, Lower A, rest, Upper pull, Lower B, rest, repeat. Two on, one off, whatever the calendar says. The order never changes, so a missed day is simply the next session you do. Pick one pattern at the start of each week and write it in the log.

Progression and troubleshooting

Moving up a rung. The trigger is 12 clean reps on every set, not one set, at the rung and tempo the week calls for. Then the next rung, from 6 to 8 reps, standard tempo. If the next rung gives fewer than 6 clean reps, stay put and slow the eccentric to 5 seconds, then 10, until it gives you 6.

A stalled ladder. Hold the rung, build reps. Two weeks with no rep gained at the same rung and tempo: drop one rung for a week, build back to 12 at a 5-second eccentric, try again. A stall on one ladder does not touch the others.

A missed session. Slot it in on the next free day and push the week along. Never double up. Two missed in one week means the plan is too big for that week: run Plan B and log it as Plan B. That is a full week.

Poor sleep. Cap the session at three sets per movement, no sets to failure, no holds, no rest-pause. Log as normal. A week of it fires the deload.

Soreness on the second lower day. Lower A and Lower B share the single-leg squat. Soreness is expected in weeks 1 to 2 and after a rung change. Reps below 6 on Lower B from soreness is logged, not fixed. Two Lower B sessions in a row below 6 at the same rung is a deload trigger.

When to stop. Muscle fatigue is the job. Sharp pain, joint pain, or pain that is still there the next morning is not. Stop the movement, substitute, and if it persists see a professional. This plan is not medical advice.

Cardio and walking

Walk most days, 20 to 40 minutes, rest days included. In a bodyweight plan this matters more than in a gym plan, because the lifting does less total work and the walking carries more of the daily energy spend. Default: a short walk after each session, a longer one on rest days.

Hard cardio is optional. If you want it, run, or row if a rower is already where you are. Twenty minutes of easy running or 15 to 20 minutes of rowing intervals, two to three times a week, on non-lifting days or after a session, never before. Nothing here assumes equipment. If the walk is the only cardio you do for eight weeks, the plan still works.

The compliance page

Plan A, the full week

- All four sessions done: Upper push, Lower A, Upper pull, Lower B.
- Every session logged with the rung, the reps per set, and the tempo used.
- Protein target hit every day. 1 g per lb of bodyweight is the default line.
- Daily weigh-in taken and the seven-day average recorded.
- Walks done on the three non-lifting days.

Plan B, the bare minimum

When the week blows up, two sessions is a full week: one upper and one lower, whichever of each is next in the order. Protein still hit every day. Walks still done. Log it as a Plan B week. A Plan B week counts. A skipped week does not.

Three questions, every night

- Did I train today, or was it a planned rest day?
- Did I hit protein?
- Did I log it?

Yes or no. Nothing else.

The gate

Eighty percent on the three questions over four weeks means the plan is working. Change nothing before week four.

Week 1 checklist

- Bodyweight Monday morning, fasted, after the bathroom.
- Photos: front, side, back.
- Read the whole of week 1 before Day 1, including the Ladders table.
- Set the four session days in a calendar, or write "rolling" and start.
- Pick the Plan B days now, before you need them.
- Test the bar, the chairs and the table with your full weight before day 1.

Discipline without integration is just a faster way to run in the wrong direction.

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Written by Stephen Dugger with help from Claude, an AI model. Every rule in this plan is his.